

Configuring Excel for RaceWorks

One-time setup for RaceWorks users

Version 2026-10-03

ABOUT THIS GUIDE

RaceWorks is an Excel workbook full of macros: small programs behind its toolbar buttons that handle event and driver entry, draw, scheduling, timing and results reporting. Out of the box, Excel blocks macros in files it doesn't know, so it needs a few settings changed once, on each computer you time with. This guide walks you through them.

It takes about ten minutes. You do it once per computer, not once per race.

Tested on: Excel 2013 (32-bit) on Windows 11. Newer versions of Excel (2016, 2019, 2021, 2024 and Microsoft 365) put these settings in the same places, but some wording and behavior differs. Where this guide describes a newer version, the information comes from Microsoft's documentation, not from testing. **Your results may vary.** If something looks different, please tell the maintainer (see *Getting help* at the end).

BEFORE YOU START

Use 32-bit Excel

RaceWorks is developed and tested only on 32-bit Excel. It has not been tested on 64-bit Excel, so use 64-bit Excel at your own risk. It's likely to work: no specific 64-bit problem is known. But if you do hit one, it may take a while to fix, so please report it to the maintainer.

To check which you have: in Excel, click **File > Account > About Excel**. The first line of the window that opens ends in "32-bit" or "64-bit".

Since Office 2019, Microsoft installs the 64-bit version unless you choose otherwise. If you are installing Office fresh, choose the 32-bit version (in Microsoft 365 it is under the additional install options). If you already have 64-bit Office, changing means uninstalling and reinstalling it.

Use a computer you control

If you can, use a personal computer, or one you control, rather than a work or school computer. On computers managed by an organization:

- the settings in this guide may be grayed out, or quietly ignored;
- security software may block parts of RaceWorks without any message;
- changing security settings may be against the organization's rules.

If you must use a managed computer and the settings are grayed out, ask your IT department to add your RaceWorks folder as a Trusted Location. Please don't try to work around their settings.

What you will set up

1. A **RaceWorks folder** in your Documents folder, to keep RaceWorks in.
2. Excel's **macro setting**: the normal, safe default.
3. A **Trusted Location**: your RaceWorks folder, so RaceWorks runs without Excel blocking it.

You make all the Excel changes with **Excel open on its own, not RaceWorks**. Step 2 explains how. The same applies whenever you come back to change a setting later.

STEP 1 - MAKE A RACEWORKS FOLDER

1. Open **File Explorer** and go to **Documents**.
2. Create a new folder called **RaceWorks**.
3. Copy the RaceWorks workbook (the `.xlsm` file) into it. Always open RaceWorks from this folder, and keep your race files here or in subfolders of it.

Keep only RaceWorks files in this folder. In Step 5 you tell Excel to trust everything in it, so any file saved here can run macros without asking. Don't save downloads or email attachments here unless they are RaceWorks files from a source you trust.

If your Documents folder is backed up to **OneDrive**, **Dropbox** or a similar service, that's a good thing: your race files are copied off the laptop as you save, provided you have internet connectivity. Read *Using OneDrive, Dropbox or another sync folder* below before race day.

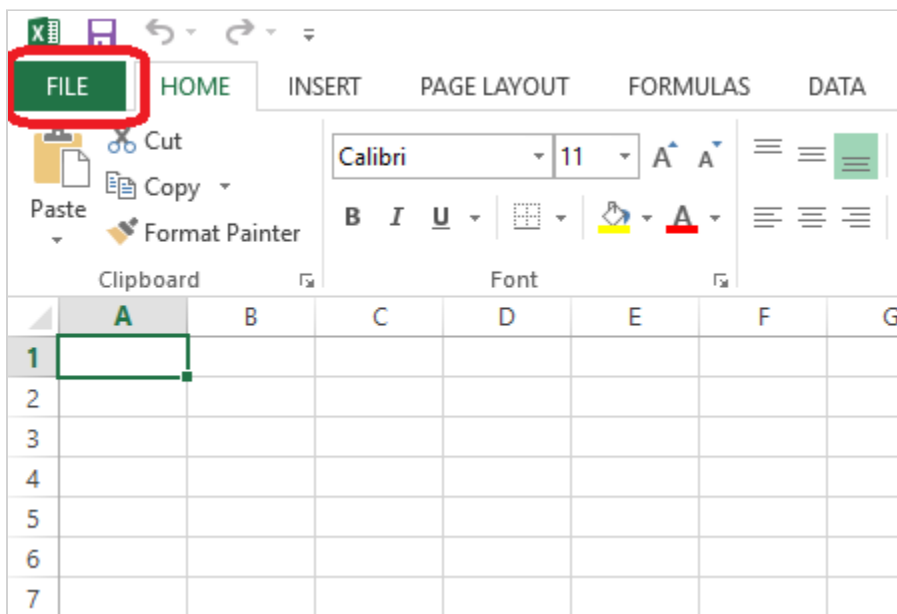
STEP 2 - OPEN THE TRUST CENTER

All of Excel's security settings live in the **Trust Center**.

Make these changes with Excel open on its own, not with RaceWorks open. RaceWorks' start-up windows get in the way, and if RaceWorks can't start properly (see *Troubleshooting*) you won't be able to reach the settings at all. Close RaceWorks (and Excel) first. Then start Excel from the **Start menu**, not by double-clicking the RaceWorks file, and choose **Blank workbook**.

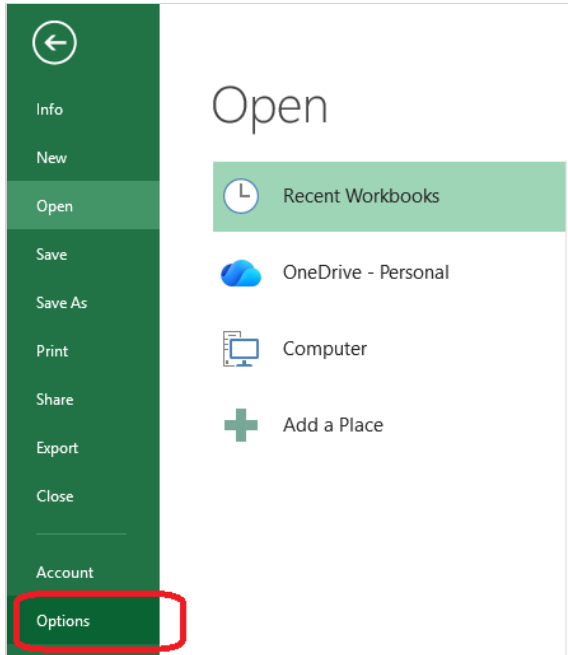
With a blank workbook open:

Click the **File** tab.



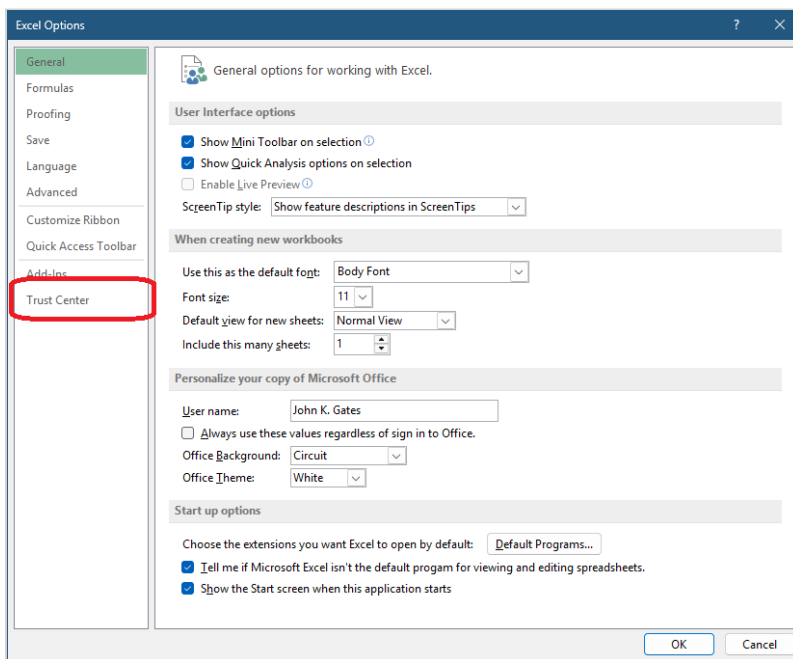
The File tab

Click **Options** at the bottom of the list on the left.



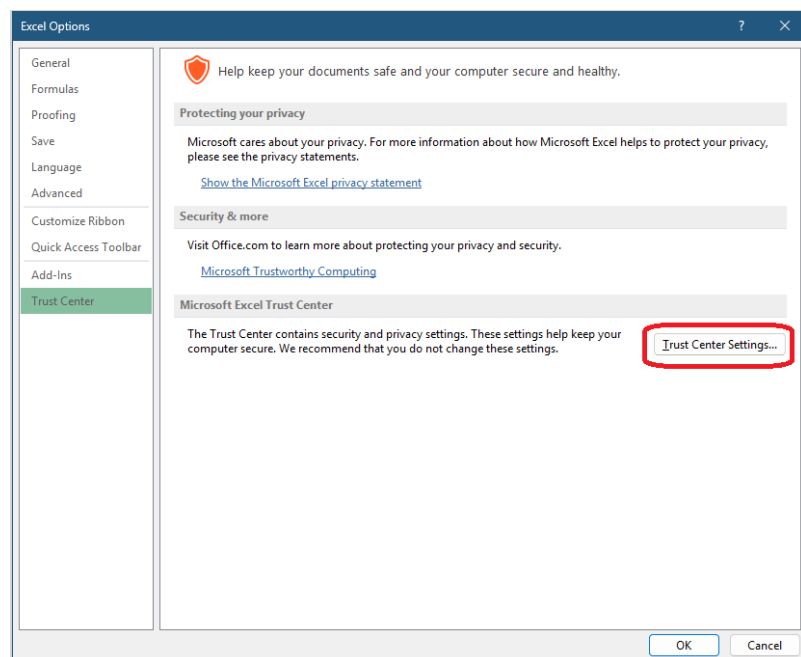
File > Options

In Excel Options, click **Trust Center** in the list on the left.



Excel Options - Trust Center

Click the **Trust Center Settings...** button.

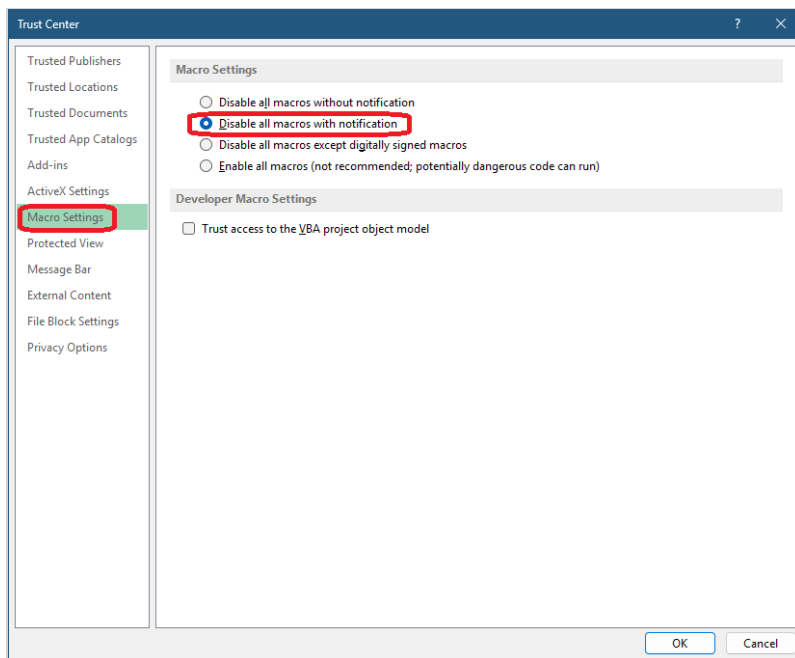


Trust Center Settings button

STEP 3 - MACRO SETTINGS

In the Trust Center, click **Macro Settings** on the left, then:

1. Under *Macro Settings*, choose **Disable all macros with notification**. This is Excel's normal default. (In newer Excel it reads *Disable VBA macros with notification*.) You do **not** need *Enable all macros*: the Trusted Location in Step 5 lets RaceWorks run.
2. Under *Developer Macro Settings*, leave **Trust access to the VBA project object model** **unticked**. RaceWorks doesn't need it. (Older versions of RaceWorks do: if Excel freezes while RaceWorks starts, see *Troubleshooting*.)

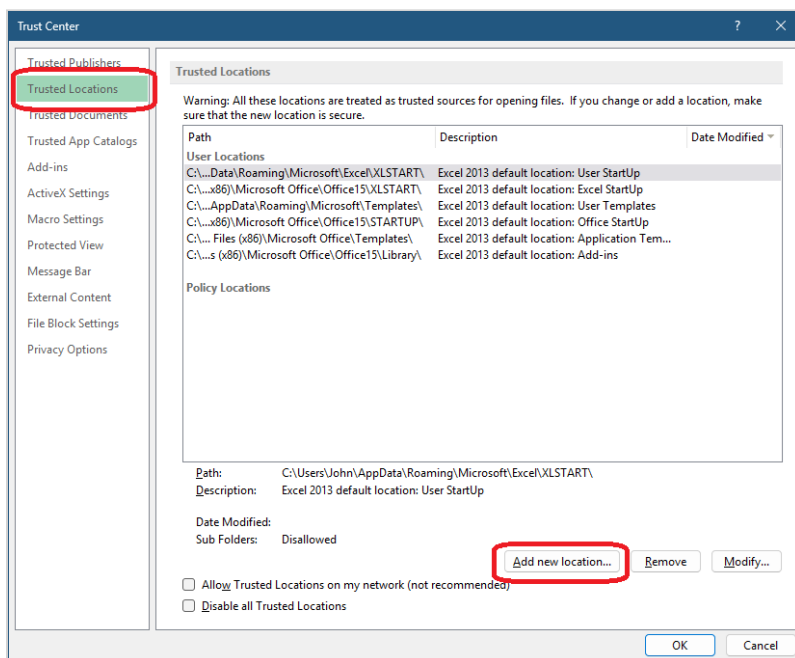


Trust Center – Macro Settings

STEP 4 - LEAVE THE NETWORK OPTION OFF

Click **Trusted Locations** on the left. At the bottom, make sure **Allow Trusted Locations on my network (not recommended)** is **not** ticked. You only need it if you run RaceWorks from a network share; see *Running RaceWorks from a network share* below.

Then click **Add new location...**



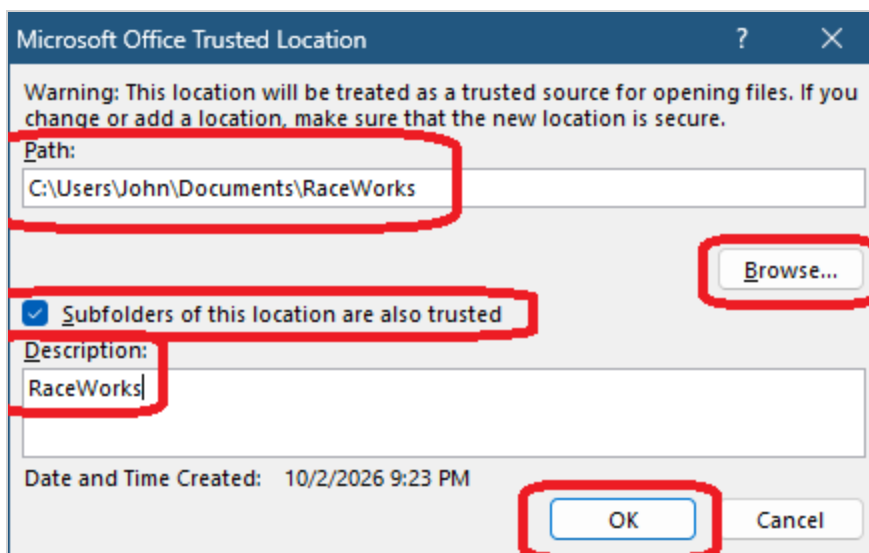
Trusted Locations – Add new location

STEP 5 - ADD YOUR RACEWORKS FOLDER AS A TRUSTED LOCATION

In the *Microsoft Office Trusted Location* window:

1. Click **Browse...**, find your **Documents > RaceWorks** folder, select it and click **OK**. Use Browse rather than typing the path: the exact path depends on your computer, and is different again if Documents is backed up to OneDrive.
2. Tick **Subfolders of this location are also trusted**, so race files in subfolders work too.
3. Optionally type a **Description**, such as *RaceWorks*.
4. Click **OK**.

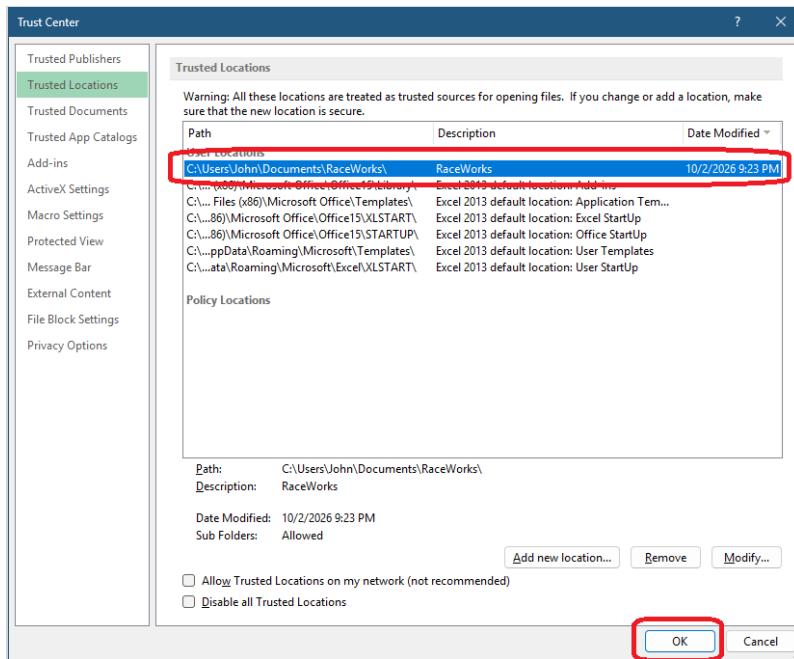
The screenshots show `C:\Users\John\Documents\RaceWorks`. Your own user name appears in place of *John*.



Trusted Location - your RaceWorks folder

Trust only the RaceWorks folder. Never add your whole Documents folder, Desktop, Downloads or a whole drive such as `C:\`. Everything in a Trusted Location can run macros without asking.

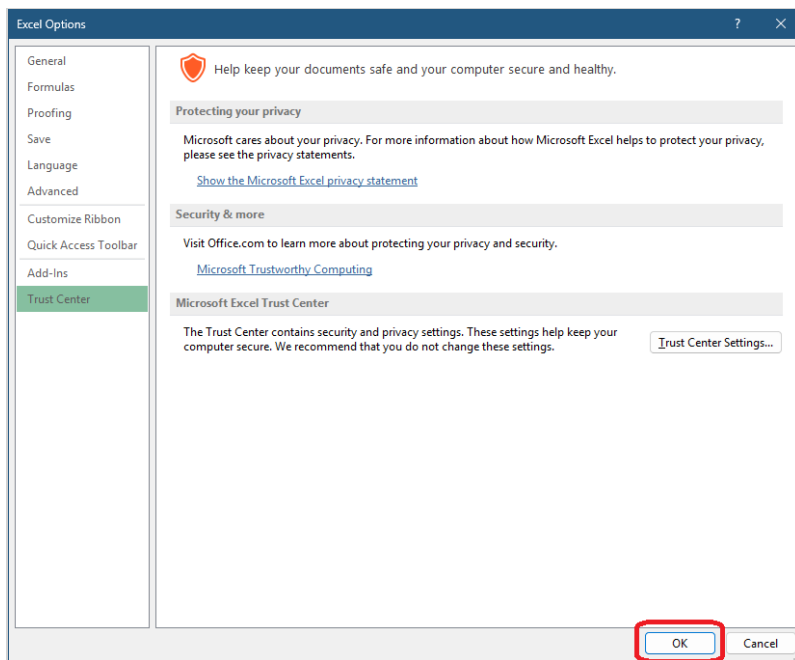
Your RaceWorks folder now appears in the list under *User Locations*. Click **OK** to close the Trust Center.



Trusted Locations – your RaceWorks folder added

STEP 6 - CLOSE EXCEL OPTIONS AND RESTART EXCEL

1. Click **OK** in Excel Options as well. If you click Cancel or close the window with the X, your changes are not saved.
2. **Close every Excel window**, so the new settings take effect.

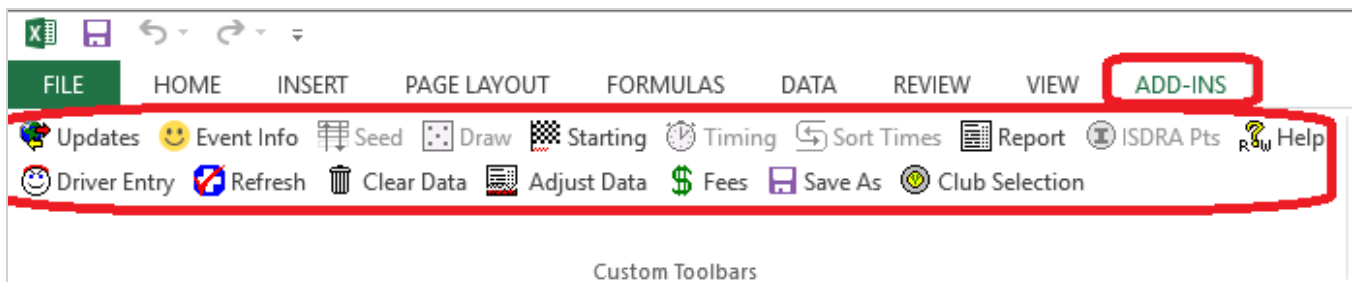


Excel Options - OK

STEP 7 - CHECK THAT IT WORKS

Open RaceWorks **from your RaceWorks folder**. If everything is set up correctly:

- there is **no** yellow or red bar across the top of the sheet;
- the RaceWorks start-up windows appear (for example, the event information form);
- the RaceWorks toolbars are on the **Add-Ins** tab of the ribbon. Some buttons are grayed out at first. That is normal: they are enabled as you work through setting up a race;
- Excel's formula bar, status bar, row and column headings and gridlines are hidden. That is normal: RaceWorks hides them on purpose.



The RaceWorks toolbars on the Add-Ins tab

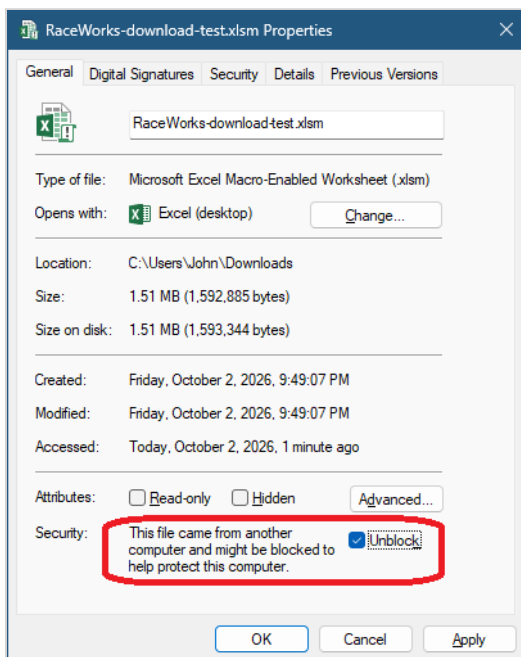
RaceWorks' own windows can't be closed with the **X** in the corner. Use the buttons on the window instead. RaceWorks windows sometimes open *behind* other windows, which makes Excel look stuck. If nothing seems to happen, press **Alt+Tab** to look for the hidden window.

Open only one RaceWorks file at a time. Excel has just one set of RaceWorks toolbars, shared by every open workbook. With two RaceWorks files open at once, the buttons can act on the wrong file. Close one RaceWorks file before opening another. (RaceWorks saves itself when you close it, so there's no "Save changes?" question.) Other spreadsheets are fine to have open alongside RaceWorks, but **close RaceWorks last** (see *Troubleshooting*).

FILES YOU RECEIVE BY DOWNLOAD OR EMAIL

Windows marks files that come from the internet or from email (this is called the *Mark of the Web*), and Excel treats them with extra suspicion.

- **Save the file straight into your RaceWorks folder.** Files in a Trusted Location skip most of these checks.
- **Then unblock it**, before you open it: right-click the file in File Explorer, choose **Properties**, tick **Unblock** at the bottom of the *General* tab, and click **OK**. (If there is no Unblock box, the file is not blocked.) Doing both covers every version of Excel.
- **ZIP files:** unblock the ZIP file *before* extracting it. Otherwise every file you extract is marked too.



File Properties – Unblock

Microsoft 365: since 2022, Microsoft 365 blocks macros completely in marked files, with a red bar that reads *SECURITY RISK: Microsoft has blocked macros from running because the source of this file is untrusted*. There is no button to enable them. Close Excel, then move the file into your RaceWorks folder and unblock it, as above. (From Microsoft's documentation; not tested.)

USING ONEDRIVE, DROPBOX OR ANOTHER SYNC FOLDER

Keeping your RaceWorks folder in a synced folder is a good idea: each time you save while the laptop has an internet connection, a copy goes to the cloud, which protects your race results if the laptop fails. Without a connection, nothing is copied until the laptop is back online; the sync service then uploads your changes. Some race sites have options for internet connectivity but some do not.

For a backup that doesn't need any connection, also copy your RaceWorks folder to a **USB stick** at the end of each race day.

However, there are a few important things to know about sync folders:

- **Make sure the files are on the laptop before you leave for the race.** OneDrive (*Files On-Demand*) and Dropbox (*online-only files*) can keep files only in the cloud, leaving a placeholder on the laptop. With no internet at the race site, such a file won't open. Right-click your RaceWorks folder and choose **Always keep on this device** (OneDrive) or **Make available offline** (Dropbox).
- **Closing doesn't undo mistakes.** RaceWorks saves itself whenever you close it, so you can't undo a mistake, such as clicking **Clear Data** by accident, by closing without saving. Keep a copy before big steps (**Save As** on the RaceWorks toolbar). OneDrive and Dropbox both keep *version history* (right-click the file > *Version history*), which can bring back an earlier copy.
- **AutoSave (Microsoft 365 with OneDrive).** For files in OneDrive, Microsoft 365 also turns on *AutoSave*, which saves every change the moment you make it, not just when you close. You can turn it off with the switch at the top left of the Excel window. Excel 2013 has no AutoSave, and Dropbox does not use it.
- **The folder path is different.** With OneDrive backup, Documents is inside your OneDrive folder (for example `C:\Users\John\OneDrive\Documents\RaceWorks`). That is why Step 5 uses **Browse...** instead of a typed path.

Not tested: Microsoft 365 with OneDrive. Microsoft 365 can open OneDrive files using a web address internally rather than the folder path. We have not been able to confirm that a Trusted Location still applies in that case. If RaceWorks shows a macro warning even though it is in your trusted RaceWorks folder on OneDrive, please tell the maintainer.

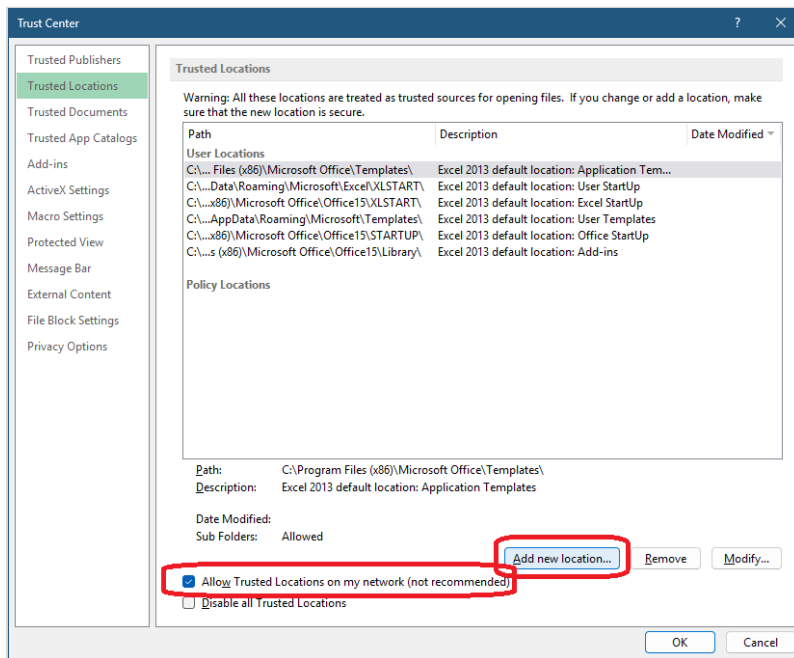
RUNNING RACEWORKS FROM A NETWORK SHARE

Most people should skip this section. It only applies if you open RaceWorks directly from a shared folder on another computer, server or NAS. Usually that means ISDRA staff or the RaceWorks maintainer, or someone working on race files from a home NAS before or after a race.

On race day, it's expected that RaceWorks would be run from the laptop itself, not a network share. If you copy RaceWorks onto your laptop and run it from your RaceWorks folder, as this guide describes above, none of this applies to you.

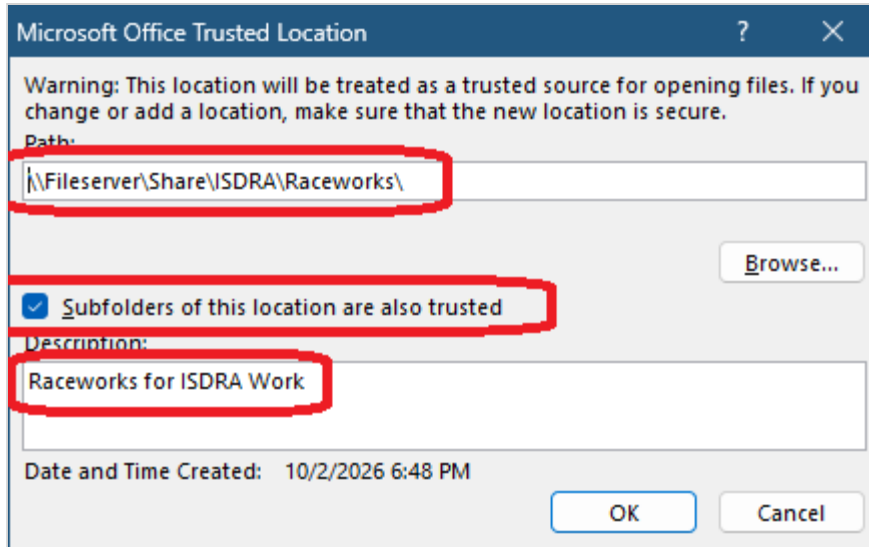
If you do run RaceWorks from a network share:

1. In **Trusted Locations**, tick **Allow Trusted Locations on my network (not recommended)**, then click **Add new location...**



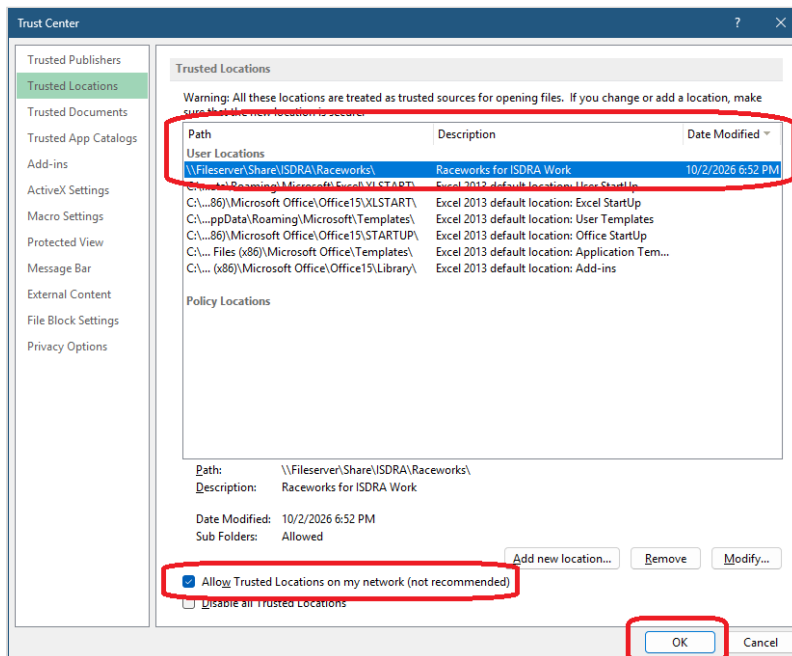
Trusted Locations - network option ticked

2. Enter the share's path, using the **server's name**, for example
\\Fileserver\Share\ISDRA\Raceworks\. Tick **Subfolders of this location are also trusted** and click **OK**.



Trusted Location – a network share

3. Check the new entry is in the list, then click **OK**.

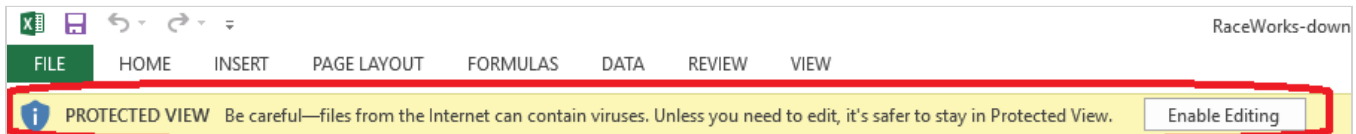


Trusted Locations list – network share added

Use the server's name, never its IP address. Windows treats any network path containing dots, such as `\\192.168.1.2\...` or `\\server.example.org\...`, as an *internet* location. Excel refuses it as a Trusted Location (it says the path *cannot be used as a Trusted Location for security reasons*) and opens files from it in Protected View. Open the file using the server's name too: a drive letter mapped to the server's name is fine, but not a recent-files entry or shortcut that uses the IP address.

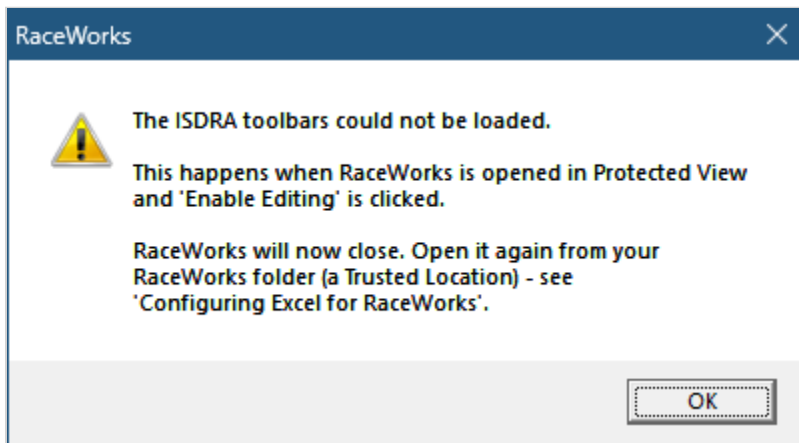
TROUBLESHOOTING

A yellow PROTECTED VIEW bar with an Enable Editing button. The file isn't in a Trusted Location: it was downloaded, emailed, opened from a network share by IP address, or opened from somewhere other than your RaceWorks folder. Don't click *Enable Editing*. Close Excel, move the file into your RaceWorks folder and unblock it (see *Files you receive by download or email*), and open it again.



The Protected View bar

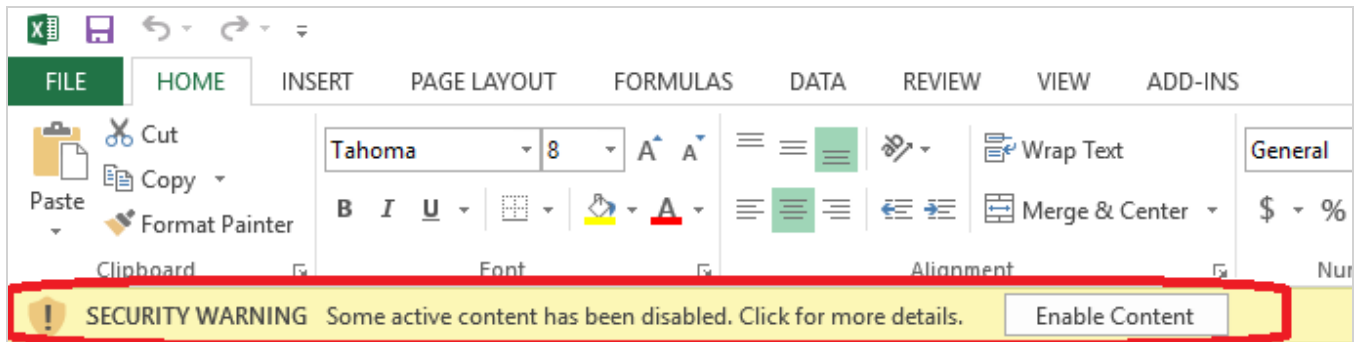
If you do click *Enable Editing* (and *Enable Content*), RaceWorks may not be able to load its toolbars. Current versions then show the message below and close the RaceWorks file (your other workbooks stay open); older versions stop with *Run-time error '91'*. Either way, open RaceWorks again from your RaceWorks folder.



The "toolbars could not be loaded" message

A yellow SECURITY WARNING bar with an Enable Content button. It may say *Some active content has been disabled, Macros have been disabled* or *External data connections have been disabled*, depending on what Excel blocked. The file is not in your Trusted Location. Close it and open RaceWorks from your RaceWorks folder. Check the folder in Step 5 is the one the file is

really in, and that *Subfolders* is ticked if the file is in a subfolder. Clicking *Enable Content* works, but only for that one file. Excel asks again if the file is renamed, moved or replaced, which happens every time you *Save As* a new race file.



The SECURITY WARNING bar

A red SECURITY RISK bar (Microsoft 365). See *Files you receive by download or email*.

Excel freezes or shows “Not Responding” while RaceWorks starts.

1. **First, press Alt+Tab.** A RaceWorks start-up window may have opened *behind* another window, which makes Excel look frozen. If you find it, carry on as normal.
2. If Excel really is stuck, close it: click the **X** at the top right of the Excel window. Windows says Excel isn't responding and offers to close it; choose **Close the program**. (If that doesn't work, press **Ctrl+Shift+Esc** to open Task Manager, select **Microsoft Excel**, and click **End task**.) Wait until Excel has completely closed; it can take a few seconds. Any unsaved work in other open Excel files is lost.
3. Start Excel **on its own**, from the Start menu, not by opening the RaceWorks file. If Excel offers to recover RaceWorks in a *Document Recovery* pane, close the pane without opening it.
4. **Older versions of RaceWorks only** freeze like this when **Trust access to the VBA project object model** is unticked. Ask the maintainer for the current version. To keep using the older one in the meantime: open a **Blank workbook**, tick that setting (Steps 2 and 3, item 2), click OK twice, and close Excel.
5. Now open RaceWorks from your RaceWorks folder.

The Trust Center settings are grayed out. Your computer is managed by an organization. Ask your IT department to add your RaceWorks folder as a Trusted Location, or use a computer you control.

The RaceWorks toolbars appear in other workbooks, even after restarting Excel. Excel keeps one set of RaceWorks toolbars for all workbooks. They are removed only when RaceWorks is the **last** workbook you close. If you close another workbook after RaceWorks, the toolbars stay behind, and Excel keeps them even after a restart. It's fine to have other spreadsheets open while you use RaceWorks. Just **close RaceWorks last**. To clear toolbars that have stayed behind, open a RaceWorks file on its own and then close it.

A “Microsoft Excel Security Notice” says *Automatic update of links has been disabled*. Click **Disable**. If this happens when you click a RaceWorks toolbar button, the toolbars are left over from another copy of RaceWorks and are trying to run that copy. Close Excel, then open the RaceWorks file you want to use on its own. (Newer versions of RaceWorks fix this automatically.)

RaceWorks says this copy has expired. Some copies of RaceWorks for race-day use stop working after a set date. Contact the maintainer for a current copy.

GETTING HELP

Contact the RaceWorks maintainer:

John K. Gates

Email: john.gates@isdra.org

Phone: 315-725-1664

Please include:

- your Excel version: **File > Account > About Excel** (the first line, including 32-bit or 64-bit);
- where the RaceWorks file is (for example *Documents > RaceWorks*, or OneDrive or Dropbox);
- a screenshot of any message or colored bar you see.

FOR IT STAFF: WHERE THESE SETTINGS LIVE

These settings are per user, in the registry under

HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Microsoft\Office\<version>\Excel\Security, where <version> is 15.0 for Excel 2013 and 16.0 for Excel 2016, 2019, 2021, 2024 and Microsoft 365.

Setting	Registry value
Macro setting	VBAWarnings: 1 = enable all, 2 = disable with notification (default), 3 = disable except digitally signed, 4 = disable without notification
Trust access to the VBA project object model	AccessVBOM: leave at 0 (off). Older versions of RaceWorks need 1
Allow Trusted Locations on my network	Trusted Locations\AllowNetworkLocations = 1
A Trusted Location	Trusted Locations\Location<n>\Path, plus AllowSubfolders = 1

Group Policy settings under

HKEY_CURRENT_USER\Software\Policies\Microsoft\Office\<version>\... override these, and gray the options out in Excel.